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Prop. 2 seeks to help California weather the next economic downturn. How we voted

BY MCCLATCHY MEDIA'S CALIFORNIA EDITORIAL BOARD

If passed, Proposition 2 would allow California to set aside a larger share of its tax revenues, raising the state's "rainy day" fund cap from 10% to 20% of annual collections. The goal would be to better prepare California for inevitable economic downturns and avoid across-the-board cuts to public services that have marked past recessions.

The ballot measure would also permit some of these reserves to be used for paying down state debts, including the $20 billion still owed to the federal government for unemployment benefits borrowed during the height of the pandemic. While supporters see Prop. 2 as responsible planning for the future, critics argue it could allow lawmakers to keep more tax revenue rather than return it to taxpayers or fund immediate needs.

Assemblymember Joe Patterson, R-Rocklin, argued against putting Prop. 2 on the ballot. He and other GOP critics see Prop. 2 as a vehicle for getting around voter-approved spending limits in California.

"All this does is create a bigger slush fund for money to be used in the following years instead of returning the money to the taxpayer.," said Patterson earlier this year.

This board has endorsed Patterson in previous election cycles. He's a good legislator, but we don't agree with him on Prop. 2.

The collective editorial boards of The Sacramento Bee, Modesto Bee, Merced Sun-Star, Fresno Bee and San Luis Obispo Tribune endorse a "yes" vote on Prop. 2 because, as the California Budget & Policy Center wrote, a larger reserve fund would help state leaders better protect vital services when revenues decline during economic downturns and reduce the need for draconian spending cuts that harm Californians.

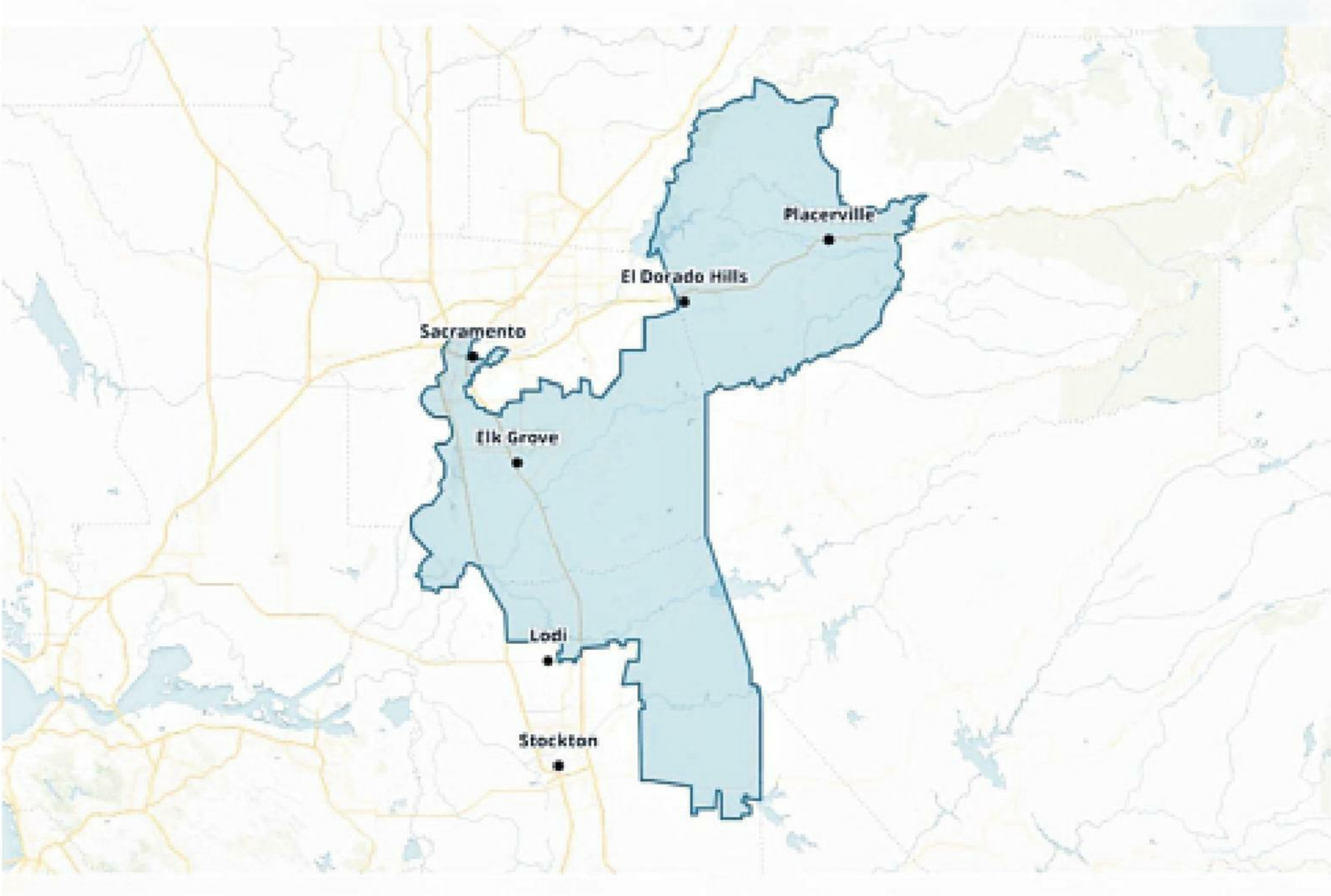
Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel agrees.

"I think government can be a force for good, but we've got to be smart about how we spend people's dollars," Gabriel told us. "That's exactly what Prop. 2 is about. It's about being smart stewards of state resources."

Under Prop. 2, saving wouldn't count as "spending" until the money is actually withdrawn and used. That's not a scheme to grow government; it's a common-sense change to make sure California can weather the next downturn without panic cuts and emergency tax hikes.

"This proposition is not necessarily about this year's budget, but it is about making sure that if there's a fire in your community five years from now, the fire department's going to be resourced and able to show up and protect you," Gabriel told the editorial board. "Or that if we have more aggressive attacks from the federal government, we'll have the ability to backfill some of that, make sure people get their health care, can be fed and make sure government is able to be there to protect our communities."

This is a critical moment for California to modernize its approach to fiscal responsibility. A vote for Prop. 2 would help California prepare for economic downturns, update outdated budget rules and protect vital public services.



The Sacramento Bee

The 7th Congressional District of California in the U.S. House of Representatives.

Doris Matsui vs. Mai Vang: The Bee's choice in Sacramento's hottest election

BY THE SACRAMENTO BEE EDITORIAL BOARD
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When The Bee endorsed Sacramento City Councilmember Mai Vang over incumbent Doris Matsui this spring in California's 7th Congressional District, it saw an opportunity for historic change in the Sacramento region. That opportunity has become more urgent as the November election approaches.

From California to New York, too many longtime Democrats cling to power, promoting their "experience" to voters frustrated with party leaders who lost the White House and Senate and failed to reclaim the House in 2024. Yet many of those leaders do not seem to understand the disconnect between them and Democratic voters

THE BEE'S VOTER GUIDE: Your guide to Sacramento's 7th District Congressional Race

Former House Speaker Nancy Pelosi still wants to run San Francisco politics, as one example, rather than gracefully support the next generation. In the United States Senate, Chuck Schumer of New York shows no capacity to evolve with the times.

In Sacramento, Matsui is hanging on. She has favored controlled appearances over debates and largely avoided the hard questions voters deserve to hear answered. When her late husband, Robert, died after serving in Congress for 26 years, she wanted to succeed him. The Democratic Party leadership here cleared the field in 2005, and she has not faced a serious re-election challenge until now.

Vang comes from a working-class background and still carries student-loan debt. Matsui, by contrast, has lent her campaign more than $1 million. For Vang, the income inequality angering so many Americans is not an abstract concern; it is part of her daily life.

An August debate underscored the choice facing voters. Matsui argues that her experience remains an asset, even as her party has grown stagnant. Vang represents a new generation and notes that she is now older than Robert Matsui was when he was elected to the House of Representatives in 1978.

Matsui has sought to portray Vang as out of step with the district's mainstream, pointing to her attendance record at local government meetings. But this race has become a referendum on Matsui and the diminishing generation of congressional Democrats who do not know when to step aside.

The Bee does not endorse candidates who refuse to meet with its editorial board. Matsui declined to participate in either a public debate with Vang or a private meeting with the board, which typically meets with candidates together in congressional races. When incumbents go years without facing serious re-election challenges, this kind of political isolation can follow.

Vang cannot lend her campaign millions from personal or family wealth. Nor does she need a cadre of consultants to tell her what to say and do. By Matsui's own admission during their debate, Vang appears to have studied Matsui's contributions from pro-Israel donors and ICE supporters more closely than Matsui has.

Matsui has earned a place in Sacramento's political history as a capable public servant who succeeded her late husband, a local political legend. But after two decades in Congress, retirement at 82 would be a fitting next chapter. Voters now have an opportunity to choose a representative ready to bring new energy and a different approach to serving greater Sacramento in Washington. The Bee endorses Mai Vang for Congress in California's 7th Congressional District.

How one man kept the water flowing in the Yolo County community of Madison

BY MATT REXROAD
Special to McClatchy Media

In a big California city, a $100 million water project is a line item spread across hundreds of thousands of ratepayers. The individual burden is small. The math for a similar project in rural California is brutal.

Unincorporated, disadvantaged communities like Madison (west of Woodland in Yolo County) are held to the same rigorous state environmental and public health standards as Los Angeles or San Francisco. Yet, Madison has fewer than 200 parcels to shoulder the cost.

When the Madison water system needs fixing, the financial burden per household can be cost-prohibitive. Yet, the need remains. It takes a specific kind of local leadership to survive in that gap. It looks less like the grandstanding you see on the news and more like Leo Refsland.

Refsland has served as the general manager of the Madison Community Services District since 2007, running a utility that supports just 450 permanent residents and 300 seasonal migrant farmworkers. He calls himself a working general manager because the district has no other full-time staff. That means his day-to-day reality spans the entire universe of public utility operation. He oversees customer billing, handles administrative work, monitors water quality, and files meticulous compliance reports required by regulatory authorities.

When the 1960s-era asbestos-cement pipelines fracture three to 12 times a year, Refsland is the one digging trenches to locate leaks and installing repair clamps. Patching the failing system costs about $1,000 per break without addressing the underlying crisis.

The permanent solution, replacing over 13,000 feet of pipeline and installing modern residential meters, required a multimillion-dollar-investment. If Madison had to fund this strictly on the backs of its few hundred local parcels, the project would have been dead on arrival.

In rural California, leaders have to fight for every infrastructure dollar. Refsland spent years securing funding and now is managing the enormous construction project himself. In 2022, he joined Yolo County leaders Elisa Sabatini and Kristin Sicke in securing a $3.8 million grant from the California Department of Water Resources. But when rising labor and material costs drove up construction bids, Madison suddenly faced a major funding shortfall.

Refsland squeezed what he could from the district's modest general fund reserves, partnered with local consulting firm Consero Solutions to chase down leads, and coordinated heavily with the Yolo County Housing Authority and local school districts. Ultimately, that grit caught the attention of the Yocha Dehe Wintun Nation, which stepped up with a critical $990,000 Doyuti T'uhkama Grant to clear the final hurdle and get shovels in the ground.

Those who work alongside Refsland know that his determination is matched by deep personal integrity. He is hardworking, diligent and honest, and uses humor to keep his project teams laughing through the stress of rain delays and utility conflicts. He is quick to express gratitude, constantly thanking the people around him, both verbally and in writing, for helping move Madison forward.

Refsland's dedication to Madison extends beyond its water system. As a founding member of the Madison Community Committee, he helps operate a food closet for residents from the district office. When the workday ends, he is a devoted family man who lights up when he talks about his wife, Cessna, his children, grandchildren and spunky cats.

Rural California needs more leaders like Leo Refsland who know how to piece together a puzzle from a dozen different spots and do the heavy lifting required to ensure their communities have a safe, reliable supply of drinking water. That is not just competent administration. In a town like Madison, that is survival.

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